Adrian Sauter

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First-year PhD student in AI Safety and Cognitively Inspired Machine Learning at Helmholtz Munich, supervised by Dr. Eric Schulz. I combine academic research, industry experience, and interdisciplinary thinking to develop AI systems that are safe, interpretable, and aligned with human values.

EDUCATION

Helmholtz Institute for Human-Centered AI — **Munich, Germany**
PhD in AI Safety — *05/2026 – Present*
- Supervisor: Dr. Eric Schulz

University of Amsterdam — **Amsterdam, Netherlands**
MSc in Artificial Intelligence (cum laude) — *09/2023 – 05/2026*
- **Thesis:** Contextual Sensitivity of Moral Beliefs in Large Language Models

University of Tuebingen — **Tuebingen, Germany**
BSc in Cognitive Science — *10/2019 – 07/2023*
- **Thesis:** Video Background Extraction with a Masked-Autoencoder-Based Neural Network

EXPERIENCE

KPN Amsterdam — **Amsterdam, Netherlands**
Research & Development Intern for XAI — *02/2025 – 08/2025*
- Researched Explainable AI for Customer Call Classification through Concept-Bottleneck Models using LLMs.

University of Amsterdam — **Amsterdam, Netherlands**
Teaching Assistant — *09/2024 – 02/2026*
- Led tutorials and seminars for graduate courses, instructing and supervising 30-200 students.

ELLIS Unit Amsterdam — **Amsterdam, Netherlands**
Project Assistant — *04/2024 – 08/2024*
- Contributed to the planning and communication of projects that are supported and organized by ELLIS.

Neuro-Cognitive Modeling Group — **Tuebingen, Germany**
Research Assistant — *03/2023 – 08/2023*
- Provided technical consultancy for professors associated with the lab, graded assignments.

Leibnitz-Institute for Knowledge Media Research — **Tuebingen, Germany**
Research Assistant — *12/2021 – 10/2022*
- Supervised in-person psychological experiments and helped analyzing the obtained data.

PUBLICATIONS

- **Sauter, A.**, Pemmasani Prabakaran, R.S., Miletić, M., & Ott, R. (2024). "Studying How to Efficiently and Effectively Guide Models with Explanations" - A Reproducibility Study. *Transactions on Machine Learning Research (TMLR).*
- Traub, M., Becker, F., **Sauter, A.**, Otte, S., & Butz, M. (2024). Loci-segmented: improving scene segmentation learning. *International Conference on Artificial Neural Network (ICANN).*
- **Sauter, A.**, Zuidema, W., & Kloots, M. D. H. (2026). The Curious Case of Visual Grounding: Different Effects for Speech-and Text-Based Language Encoders. *IEEE International Conference on Acoustics, Speech and Signal Processing (ICASSP).*
- **Sauter, A.**, Neplenbroek, V., Vlassopoulos, G., & Bardelloni, G. (2026). Actionable Interpretability for Churn Classification: A Text Bottleneck Model Case Study at a Major Telecom Provider. *The 64th Annual Meeting of the Association for Computational Linguistics--Industry Track (ACL).*
- **Sauter, A.**, & Schirmer, M. (2026). On the Context Sensitivity of LLM Moral Judgment. *Proceedings of the 2026 Conference on Empirical Methods in Natural Language Processing (EMNLP).*